

20-21). You have to read the signs," Singh tells INDIA TODAY. He says the party is suffering from something akin to physical indolence, and an erosion of the will to fight. New Delhi's policy stances do not help: Singh opposes the Centre's jute policy and the Rs 6,500 a quintal cap on raw jute that he alleges is decimating the industry. He has now written to Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee, seeking her intervention.

It's into this scenario of gloom that Union home minister Amit Shah's visit to Bengal—his first ever since the 2021 assembly polls—unfolds on May 5. His aim is to galvanise the local unit, but it may take some doing. Witness the sloth it has been plagued by. In the past 11 months, Bengal has witnessed several allegations against the TMC, its leaders and its administration—cases of post-poll violence, rapes, murder, the Bogtui killing and scams in the education department. To each of them, the BJP's response has been inexplicably timid. "The state suffered a complete breakdown of law and order for a month...yet the BJP couldn't engineer mass movements or draw the nation's attention. Had Mamata been in the Opposition, she would have stalled life with a parade of dead bodies of victims by now," says a BJP leader. Truly, 'fact-finding teams' under central leaders did trudge up to trouble spots, and local protests were duly organised, but there was no united show of strength.

Behind the inertia is the basic fact that the Bengal BJP is a divided house, whose top leaders don't see eye to eye. "They use up all their energy to fight among themselves. Where will they get the energy to fight the TMC?" asks the party leader. After Mamata held her own against the BJP's stunning electoral siege in May 2021, the cracks had started showing in the challenger's phalanx. Especially galling for the party were the bitter exchanges between veteran BJP leader Tathagata Roy and then state BJP president Dilip Ghosh. Ghosh was replaced as state unit chief by Balurghat MP Sukanta Majumdar in September 2021, but not before much loss of morale among the cadre.

SUVENDU RUNS A PARALLEL POWER CENTRE, KEEPS COMPANY WITH NEW BJP LEADERS AND CALLS THE SHOTS IN THE ASSEMBLY

The new chief tried to recreate a sense of order: he put in place a new state committee, announced a new list of district unit presidents, and made changes in sundry party cells. But many senior leaders were ignored, and turmoil resulted. Seniors like Ghosh, Ritesh Tewari and Sayantan Basu are finding it hard to accept a generational shift. The Matuas, a key caste group brought into the saffron fold before 2019, are also unhappy for being under-represented in these bodies and for the Centre's slowness in implementing the Citizenship Amendment Act.

Besides, there's the matter of Leader of the Opposition and TMC renegade Suvendu Adhikary becoming too powerful, a fact intensely disliked by leaders who have been with the party for years. By favouring Suvendu, the central leadership has, unwittingly or otherwise, fostered a new divide. Suvendu runs a parallel power centre, keeps company with leaders who joined the BJP before the 2021 poll and calls the shots in the assembly. The desertion by many such 'new' BJP leaders after the party's assembly poll rout has rightly made the old guard cagey. "The assimilation of original BJP and Trinamool-turned-BJP can never be organic. It was a marriage of convenience and was bound to terminate. The exodus is natural. Most of the deserters are career politicians... they see no future here," says Sovonlal Dutta Gupta, retired head of political science in Calcutta University.

Inconstant and warring leaders have spread confusion, but BJP cadres have been jumping ship too. Especially those who faced alleged TMC violence and felt abandoned after the 2021 poll. "We found surrendering to the TMC and paying up a fine easier and safer than hiding. We hoped the leaders would stand by us but...no one came, even our local MP went missing," says a farmer of North 24 Parganas who had to pay a fine of Rs 30,000 and surrender his job cards to enter his locality.

Besides, the BJP's claim to be a true alternative—beyond Hindutva bombast—is under strain. "Central agencies came close to charging some TMC heavyweights in various scams, but they were let off the hook mysteriously. The biggest blunder the BJP did was making a Narada scam accused Leader of the Opposition," says a senior BJP leader from North Bengal. The overall sense is that of a blunted edge, with a hard-won advantage being forfeited. Amit Shah has his work cut out. ■